While Akbar was being initiated, albeit reluctantly, into a more formal and visible role as a Mughal mirza, life continued in its prosaic, everyday way in the harem, where he remained the cossetted and adored child of the women. At the age of six he suffered a bout of toothache, for which Bega Begum brought a remedy from her stores. Hamida Banu, however, was immediately vigilant, terrified of poison at a time when royal children's lives were extremely threatened. Bega Begum, sympathetic to Hamida Banu's fears, first swallowed some of the medicine herself before giving it to Akbar and so 'the minds of those present were set at rest…and also my pain soothed', remembered Akbar. Indeed, Akbar loved Bega Begum dearly and admitted later to Abu'l Fazl that 'the kindness and affection which she showed to me and my love for her are beyond expression. Everyone who did not know the real facts [that she was his stepmother], thought that she was my own mother.'

A certain calm may have prevailed in the harem, but this was not true of much of the rest of the Mughal court. Humayun had been involved in a series of deadly skirmishes with Kamran over control of Badakhshan and Kabul. It was during one such almost desultory raid that Hindal was killed, long after he had joined Humayun and was fighting for the Padshah. The harem was inconsolable and Gulbadan wrote about her grief over the death of this youngest son of Babur with almost unconsoled sorrow, fifty years later, when she said 'would to Heaven that merciless sword had touched my heart and eyes, or Saadat Yar, my son's, or Khizr Khwaja Khan's[*]! Alas! A hundred regrets! Alas! A thousand times alas!'

With the death of the first of his uncles, Akbar was suddenly catapulted into the much more incendiary world of Mughal politics at the age of nine. He inherited all of Hindal's entourage and his lands around Ghazni and this appanage was now his to govern entirely. He also inherited a more fragile and complicated thing, his nine-year-old cousin, Ruqaiya Begum. It was a Timurid custom for cousins to marry and, at this point, the young cousins were betrothed to one another. But perhaps Akbar, at this stage immersed in the world of his kokas, their roughhouse fights, the hunts and the pigeons, revolted at the idea of having to even consider this girl as a future bride. Much later in his life, Akbar would work hard to convince his subjects about the evils of child marriage and his vehemence seems to have arisen from a bleak and personal space. He would raise the marriageable age of boys to sixteen and girls to fourteen, and would forbid the marrying of